Lesson 14: Paraphrasing and Summarizing

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.8: Paraphrasing and Summarizing.

In this lesson

You will compare a quotation, a paraphrase and a summary of the same passage, check the models carefully against the original, write your own paraphrase, and summarize a full article in five sentences and then in 25 words. Paraphrasing and summarizing are how you use sources in essays, reports and exam answers: they show that you understand a text, and they keep your writing in your own words.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain how quotations, paraphrases and summaries are similar and how they differ.
- Paraphrase a passage with new words and a new sentence structure while keeping the meaning exact.
- Check a paraphrase or summary against the original, fact by fact.
- Summarize an article with its title, author and main idea, in five sentences and in 25 words.
- Introduce source ideas with a range of reporting verbs.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
quotation	the exact words of a source, in quotation marks	Sayil Camacho states, "an estimated 1.1 million undocumented children live in the United States …"
paraphrase	the ideas of a passage in your own words and sentence structure, at about the same length	We can paraphrase a passage to show our comprehension.
summary	a much shorter text that gives only the main idea and key points	A summary is always significantly shorter than the original text.
reporting verb	a verb that introduces a source's idea	states, claims, explains, suggests, warns, acknowledges
condense	make shorter but keep the important content	A summary condenses the text.
key term	a technical word you may keep in a paraphrase because it has no good synonym	Use your own words, unless a key term is essential.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
sentence structure	the grammar pattern of a sentence	Use a different sentence structure: change up the grammar!
academic conventions	the usual rules of academic style	Avoid "you", contractions and qualifiers like really or very.
contraction	a short form such as isn't or don't	Use "is not" instead of "isn't".
qualifier	a word that makes another word stronger or weaker, such as really or very	Avoid qualifiers like really / very.
transition word	a word that connects ideas	Furthermore, this number includes 45,000 graduate students.
refute / acknowledge	argue that something is wrong / admit that something is true	The authors acknowledge that their study has limits.

Rules and explanations

Paraphrasing

We paraphrase to show that we understand a text, or to support a point in an essay. A paraphrase captures what the text says. With a paraphrase we:

- keep the length similar to the original;
- use our own words, different from the text (a key term may stay);
- keep the meaning the same, and add no opinion;
- use a different sentence structure;
- give the writer's name and the title of the text.

Summarizing

A summary can be one sentence, a paragraph, a page or a whole essay, but it is always significantly shorter than the original. A strong summary:

- starts with an introductory sentence that gives the title, the author and the main idea (thesis) in your own words: In "Title," Author states that ...;
- uses your own words, condenses the text and gives an overview;
- captures the key points and leaves out most details, examples, illustrations and explanations;
- contains only the ideas of the original, not your opinion;
- follows academic conventions: no "you", no contractions, no qualifiers like really or very; after the first mention, the writer's last name only;
- looks like a paragraph and makes sense, with transition words between points.

Steps: 1. preview the text; 2. annotate it; 3. find the main idea; 4. write a one-sentence summary of each paragraph in your own words; 5. write one sentence that summarizes the whole text; 6. put the key points in a logical order; 7. connect them with transition words; 8. avoid repetition.

Reporting verbs

Instead of "states", choose the verb that matches what the writer does: claims, explains, defends, insists, asserts, compares, warns, observes, condemns, suggests, refutes, shows, acknowledges. (Unit 4 returns to reporting verbs.)

Check the meaning

Quotations, paraphrases and summaries all report ideas from the original, so every number, name and source must stay correct. After you write, compare your version with the original sentence by sentence. Exercise 2 shows why.

> **In psychology (APA style):** the book's pattern names the title ("In 'Title,' author states that ..."). Psychology papers usually give the author's surname and the year instead: Adelman and Reid (2020) found that ..., or (Adelman & Reid, 2020) at the end of the sentence. APA also prefers the past tense (found, reported) or the present perfect (have shown) when you report research.
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> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Changing only a few words of the original sentence still counts as copying. Change the structure too: start with a different subject, turn a verb into a noun, or split or join sentences. - Arabic texts often repeat key words to connect ideas. In an English summary, avoid repetition (step 8): use pronouns, synonyms and transition words.

Practice

Exercise 1. Quotation, paraphrase and summary. Look at Table 1.8.1 in the lesson material: a quotation, a paraphrase and a summary of a passage from "What the Supreme Court's DACA Ruling Means for Undocumented Students and the Colleges and Universities They Attend, Today" by Sayil Camacho. Write three similarities and three differences. Do not read the list under the table until you finish.

Exercise 2. Is the meaning exact? Compare the model paraphrase and the model summary in Table 1.8.1 with the quotation, fact by fact.

1. Which fact in the quotation is missing from the paraphrase?
2. According to the paraphrase, what does the Census Bureau data show? What does the quotation say?
3. The paraphrase calls the 450,000 students "undergraduate students". Why is this wrong?
4. The summary says that "100,000 are in high school". What does the quotation say?
5. Which of the five paraphrasing rules does the model paraphrase follow, and which does it break?

Exercise 3. Write a paraphrase. Paraphrase the passage in the Quotation column of Table 1.8.1 (three sentences). Follow all five rules, and keep every number and its source correct.

Exercise 4. Summarize an article. Use "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds" by Robert M. Adelman and Lesley Reid. (The book says it is in section 1.4; it is in section 1.5, in the Lesson 12 material.)

1. Write notes: author and title; main idea; 1-3 supporting details.

2. Use your notes to write a summary in five sentences or fewer.
3. Condense your summary to 25 words, not counting the authors' names and the title.
4. Was it hard to condense the article to 25 words? Why or why not?

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my paraphrase of the Camacho passage: [paste]. Is it too close to the original? Is every number and source still correct?"
- "Here is my five-sentence summary of the Adelman and Reid article: [paste]. Did I include the main idea, leave out minor details and avoid my own opinion?"
- "Read me one sentence at a time from a PSYC 110 lecture. I will paraphrase each one aloud. Tell me if I changed the meaning."
- "Let's do the 25-word challenge with the UNICEF report from Lesson 12. Count my words and tell me what important point I lost."
- "Give me a situation, for example 'the author admits a weakness' or 'the author says another idea is wrong', and I will choose the best reporting verb."

Read aloud

1. A summary can be short or long, but it is always significantly shorter than the original text.
2. In "What the Supreme Court's DACA Ruling Means for Undocumented Students ...," Sayil Camacho states that over a million children are in the United States without legal papers.
3. Camacho adds that colleges and universities currently enroll about 450,000 students without legal status.
4. The authors acknowledge that their study describes broad patterns rather than specific cities.
5. Adelman and Reid report that a larger undocumented population did not raise violent crime.
6. Word stress: PAR·a·phrase, SUM·ma·rize, SUM·ma·ry, con·DENSE, ac·KNOWL·edge, re·FUTE, as·SERT.

Writing task

A summary and a paraphrase. Choose one text:

- a section of a PSYC 110 lecture transcript, for example Lecture 20, Chapter 4, "Getting Used to Happiness", or Lecture 8, Chapter 5, "The Power of Suggestion on Memory";
- a short section of the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* (https://openstax.org/details/books/psychology-2e), for example on sleep or stress;
- a reading from this unit: the UNICEF report or the Nguyen editorial (Lesson 12), or "The Dreamers" (Lesson 15).

Write:

1. A summary paragraph of 100-150 words. Follow the eight steps.

2. A paraphrase of one important passage of 2-3 sentences. Copy the original above your paraphrase.

Checklist:

- The first sentence gives the title, the author (or speaker) and the main idea in your own words, with a reporting verb.
- The summary is much shorter than the original and keeps only key points.
- There is no opinion of yours in the summary or the paraphrase.
- The paraphrase is about as long as the original, with different words and a different structure.
- Every number, name and source is correct: you checked them against the original.
- No "you", no contractions, no really or very; the author's last name after the first mention.
- Transition words connect the points, and no idea is repeated.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 Similarities (book): all three use reporting words to refer to the source; all three report ideas from the original text; paraphrases and summaries both change the words and the sentence structure. Differences (book): only quotations use the exact words of the original; quotations use quotation marks to show the copied words; summaries are shorter than the original, while quotations and paraphrases are close to the original length.

Exercise 2

1. "about 100,000 undocumented students who graduate from high school every year."
2. The paraphrase says that the latest Census Bureau data shows almost half a million undocumented students in higher education. In the quotation, the Census Bureau data is the source of the 1.1 million figure for children; the 450,000 figure comes from "the most recent estimates", with no source named.
3. The 450,000 includes "some 45,000 pursuing advanced degrees", that is, graduate students. The paraphrase even contradicts itself in the next sentence ("this number includes 45,000 students who are enrolled in graduate school").
4. About 100,000 undocumented students graduate from high school every year: a yearly number of graduates, not the number of students in high school. The summary also says "of which", so it suggests that all the college and graduate students are among the 1.1 million children; the quotation does not say this.
5. It follows four rules: similar length, own words, different sentence structure, and the writer's name and title. It breaks the rule "keep the meaning the same": it moves the Census Bureau source, adds the wrong word "undergraduate", and leaves out the 100,000 graduates.

Exercise 3 (example answer) In The Conversation's "What the Supreme Court's DACA Ruling Means for Undocumented Students and the Colleges and Universities They Attend, Today," Sayil Camacho reports that, according to Census Bureau data, roughly 1.1 million children living in the United States lack legal immigration status, and around 100,000 of them finish high school each year. Camacho adds that colleges and universities currently enroll about 450,000 students without legal status, according to recent estimates, and that roughly one in ten of these students (some 45,000) is working toward a graduate degree.

Exercise 4

1. (example answer) Robert M. Adelman and Lesley Reid, "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds" (The Conversation). Main idea: undocumented immigration does not raise violent crime in U.S. metropolitan areas and may lower property crime. Details: a study of 154 metropolitan areas with two population estimates and FBI crime data; on average, more undocumented residents, no change in violent crime and less property crime; limits: broad patterns only, no explanation of the reasons.

2. (example answer) In "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds," Robert M. Adelman and Lesley Reid report that undocumented immigration does not raise violent crime in U.S. metropolitan areas and may even lower property crime. The authors explain that earlier research, including their own, had found that immigration does not increase crime, but critics argued that such studies could not distinguish undocumented immigrants from immigrants as a whole. To answer this criticism, Adelman and Reid analyzed FBI crime data together with two separate estimates of the undocumented population in 154 metropolitan areas. Their statistical analysis showed that, on average, a larger undocumented population had no effect on violent crime and was linked to lower property crime, a result that builds on a 2018 review of 51 earlier studies. However, the authors acknowledge that their study describes broad patterns across metropolitan areas rather than specific cities, and that it does not explain the reasons for the link between immigration and lower crime.
3. (example answer, 23 words without the title and names) In "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer ...," Adelman and Reid report that, across 154 U.S. metropolitan areas, a larger undocumented population did not raise violent crime and may have lowered property crime.
4. (example answer) It was hard, because I had to leave out the evidence and the limits of the study and keep only the main finding. Choosing short, general words (population, raise, lower) helped.

My notes